America the Beautiful – A Program

By Katharine Lee Bates; Langston Hughes and the Poets of Russell Simmons Def Poetry Jam on Broadway

America the Beautiful by Katharine Lee Bates

(May choose to sing his stanza)

O beautiful for spacious skies,

For amber waves of grain,

For purple mountain majesties

Above the fruited plain!

America! America!

God shed His grace on thee,

And crown thy good with brotherhood

From sea to shining sea!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Katharine Lee Bates
ISBN: 978-0689852459
Publisher: Atheneum Books for Young Readers
Date (Month/Year): June 2002

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INTRODUCTION

In February of 2014, Coca Cola's entry into the Super Bowl ad campaign had a message that was a Coke Classic: it celebrated the many kinds, colors, lifestyles and origins of Americans. Over a collage of American faces, young, old, brown, white, straight, gay, in cowboy hats and hijabs, played a patriotic song -- "America the Beautiful" sung in eight languages.

Who knew the commercial would cause such an uproar? Conservatives instantly lit up social media with objections -- many vowing to boycott the soda company's products as "un-American."

America the Beautiful – A Program of poems by Katharine Lee Bates (circa 1900); Langston Hughes (circa 1960) and the Poets of Russell Simmons Def Poetry Jam on Broadway (circa 2003).

I, Too, Sing America by Langston Hughes

I, too, sing America.

I am the darker brother.

They send me to eat in the kitchen

When company comes,

But I laugh,

And eat well,

And grow strong.

Tomorrow,

I'll be at the table

When company comes.

Nobody'll dare

Say to me,

"Eat in the kitchen,"

Then.

Besides,

They'll see how beautiful I am

And be ashamed—

I, too, am America.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Langston Hughes
Book: Collected Poems of Langston Hughes
ISBN: 978-0679764083
Publisher: Vintage
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1995

TRANSITION

America -- no other place in the world has such a diverse population. And yet, culturally speaking, we as a nation have difficulty thinking of anybody who doesn't have white skin and whose first language isn't English as "American." Just how beautiful is America?

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I Write America

(Poets for each stanza denoted within)

I write America a Dear John letter

I'm not leaving but things have to

get better

Learn to pronounce my name correctly

I am a taxpayer

and brick layer

These poems are us

Our history,

you have no choice but to recognize

me and mine

for the fire next time,

I rewrite America -- ***Suheir Hammad***

I write America for the people just like me,

too busy blamin' instead of claiming

that America is the best place to be.

This is my family

Yea, my kin folk have problems and issues

like every family does

but I'm going to make my difference right

here

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for us
I write America -- ***Poetri***

I dream America for the day I won't have
to hyphenate my identity
For the day everyone will be tri-lingual
For the day I won't be asked where I'm
really from or complimented on how
well I speak English
For the day the American dream includes me
I write America -- ***Mayda Del Valle***

I write America for the
not-so-funny-face
of Will and Grace
That dear old, queer old USA
Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston,
James Baldwin . . .
For the voices who broke the silence
I write America. -- ***Staceyann Chin***

I will always write America for the poor people
And I'm not trying to tell you how to live

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but vanity will kill you so will MTV Cribs
For the poor people, I write America. -- ***Lemon***

I write America
love notes in my protest poems
Because this is my home
Because between the shining seas
and redwood forests
I am one voice in a chorus
composing ourselves from wounded knees
We write America
because even when it's not
we assume that it's free
We write America. -- ***Steve Colman***

I would write America
but I'm too suspicious
I know
the powers that be
are vicious
and they wouldn't
have a problem
sacrificing the lives
of twenty-five hundred people

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at the bottom of Manhattan
in order
to boost their economy.
See, they've been sacrificing the lives
of the youth around my way
to fill their filthy pockets
since I can remember
So instead
I just watch America. -- ***Black Ice***

I have to write America
Because no one else will do it for me
Chinatown is America,
Bruce Lee is America
my mother is America.
My people
you should never have to accent less
never view yourselves as other
and never have to
fear internment again
I am America. -- ***Beau Sia***

I CHANGE AMERICA . . . by living life to the fullest
Fight those who try to pull s*** and always

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resist the unjust system
I serve only Him or She, so
I write to free my brothers and sisters
no matter what the color.
Speak only the truth
so the blind can see
WE MUST MAKE AMERICA
A TRUE DEMOCRACY -- ***Georgia Me***

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Various Authors (denoted within poem)
Book: Russell Simmons Def Poetry Jam on Broadway . . . and More
ISBN: 978-0743476218
Publisher: Atria Books
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier – MS (Complete Program)
IL State Qualifier (I Write America)
MN State Qualifier (I, Too, Sing America)
2007 National Qualifier (I, Too, Sing America)

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